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California lawmakers head back to work, as they tackle a stack of high-profile bills

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Good morning and welcome to the A.M. Alert!

CALIFORNIA LAWMAKERS HEAD BACK TO WORK

Summer break is over, and the halls of the Capitol are once more teeming with lawmakers, staffers and lobbyists as they go about the people's business.

On Monday, they're jumping back into the mix, with the Senate Appropriations Committee set to hold a hearing on many bills we've been following this year.

There's AB 28, Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel's proposal for an excise tax on firearms and ammunition. The money would go toward gun violence prevention programs.

AB 38, by Assemblyman Alex Lee, would establish standards for light pollution in residential zones.

Assemblyman Chris Holden's AB 280 would restrict the use of solitary confinement in California jails or prisons. Gov. Gavin Newsom vetoed a previous version.

Another bill up for consideration during Monday's hearing is the so-called "Skittles Bill." AB 418 by Assemblyman Gabriel, would ban certain chemicals from being used in foods and beverages.

Assemblyman Corey Jackson's AB 1078, which would require school boards to accurately portray California's cultural and racial diversity, will also be considered.

Meanwhile, the Assembly Appropriations Committee returns with a hearing on Wednesday.

Lawmakers will take up a number of measures, including SB 14, Sen. Shannon Grove's bill to make child sex trafficking a three strikes felony; SB 58, Sen. Scott Wiener's proposal to decriminalize certain psychedelics; SB 403, by Sen. Aisha Wahab, which would add caste to the list of statuses covered by the state's anti-discrimination law, and SB 447, Sen. Toni Atkins' bill to replace California's travel ban with a LGBTQ advocacy program.

BONTA CONDEMNS MURRIETA VALLEY SCHOOL DISTRICT

Last week, the Murrieta Valley Unified School District board voted in favor of a policy of outing transgender students to their parents.

According to the Press-Enterprise, School Board President Paul Diffley defended the measure that he introduced, saying, "To me the importance of the bond between student and family, mother and father, is paramount."

This decision followed in the footsteps of the Chino Valley Unified School District, which enacted a similar policy earlier this summer, prompting California Attorney General Rob Bonta to launch a civil rights investigation.

Bonta issued a statement Friday saying that he is "deeply disturbed" by the actions of the Murrieta Valley Unified school board.

"My office remains committed to ensuring school policies do not target or seek to discriminate against California's

most vulnerable communities. California will not stand for violations of our students' civil rights," Bonta said.

Also criticizing the decision was the group Our Schools USA, a national advocacy organization "created to protect parents and students from extremist school boards," according to a statement from the group.

Co-founder Kristi Hirst said in a statement that the policy "breaks down trust between our most vulnerable students and their teachers."

"Murrieta following the lead of Chino Valley — with copies of Chino Valley's illegal resolution in hand — makes it clear that attacking LGBTQ students for political gain is part of a larger inorganic movement that Our Schools USA is fighting against," Hirst said.

SEIU CALIFORNIA OFFERS ENDORSEMENTS

SEIU California, a powerful union with more than 700,000 members statewide, last week announced endorsements in a number of legislative races.

Candidates picking up a union endorsement included Democrats Will Rollins in Congressional District 41, Kathryn Lybarger in Senate District 7, Michelle Chambers in Senate District 35 and Paula Villescaz in Assembly District 6.

"SEIU members have made our choices and placed the power of our endorsement behind leaders who will fight alongside us for the California our children deserve," said SEIU California President David Huerta in a statement. "SEIU members are fired up to elect leaders who know California will only become more equitable and just by empowering workers."

QUOTE OF THE DAY

"Robust urban rail systems are transformational. Many U.S. cities removed their rail systems at the behest or car & oil companies. We're paying the price for those decisions every day. Let's commit to rebuilding them, in CA & beyond, & making our cities safer & more sustainable."

- Sen. Scott Wiener, D-San Francisco, via Twitter.

Best of The Bee:

Rancho Cordova residents: Whether you've never attended a city council meeting or you're a vocal city hall regular, the next few months might be a good time to tune in to your local politics, via Sonora Slater.Some immigrant Californians can still receive up to $4,500 if they were impacted by the series of storms that bombarded the state from December to April, via Mathew Miranda.Three downtown Sacramento buildings that once served as office space for state workers are one step closer to becoming housing low- and middle-income Sacramentans, via Maya Miller.There is a new pack of wolves in California, via Joshua Tehee.Gov. Gavin Newsom announced the deployment of 11 members from California search-and-rescue task forces to assist the hardest hit areas from devastating wildfires in Maui that have killed at least 53 people last week in Hawaii, via Hannah Shields.

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